

Korea Views: May MPC Preview — A Measured Hawkish Turn

- We expect the Bank of Korea Monetary Policy Committee to sound incrementally more hawkish on upside inflation risks at its first meeting under Governor Shin Hyun-song, reflecting ongoing Middle East energy disruptions and a renewed pickup in metropolitan housing prices. That said, we expect guidance to remain measured, given uncertainty around the duration and intensity of the energy shock and still-anchored inflation expectations. Policy uncertainty also remains over how the government will use sizable excess tax revenues—estimated at more than 5% of GDP—generated by major Korean memory producers.
- We expect the BOK to raise its 2026 growth forecast from 1.9% toward the 2.5% consensus. While Q1 GDP was an upside surprise, we do not expect the Bank to move materially above 2.5%, given the drag from prolonged energy disruptions and a still-narrow, tech-led recovery. With tech accounting for only around 10% of GDP and 1% of employment, the recovery remains too narrow to justify a meaningfully stronger growth upgrade.
- We expect the BOK to raise its 2026 CPI forecast from 2.3%, but likely only modestly. Persistently high energy prices are the main driver, but still-anchored inflation expectations and soft non-tech activity and labor market conditions should limit the scale of any upward revision. Headline CPI rose to 2.6% yoy in April, broadly in line with expectations, with momentum led by oil-related goods and services. High-frequency data points to stabilizing inflation momentum in May. Meanwhile, Seoul housing prices have resumed rising since mid-March, reviving concerns around housing market overheating.
- We see support for Korean bonds from both WGBI inclusion and the AI-driven super surplus. Strong chip revenues could raise interim excess tax payments by KRW60trn in August, expanding the fiscal buffer and helping reduce FX market imbalances. While financial outflows have been a major source of KRW weakness in recent years, we think the scale and persistence of the improving current account can more than offset those depreciation pressures.
- Our BOK terminal rate forecast remains 3.00% by end-2026, with 25bp hikes in both July and October. It would remain below both the 3.5% peak reached in the previous post-pandemic hiking cycle and current market pricing of 4.25%. We see risks to our rate view as broadly balanced, with the energy price path and the fiscal treatment of excess tax revenues the two main swing factors.

Goohoon Kwon, CFA

+852-2978-0048 |
goohoon.kwon@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C.

Irene Choi

+82(2)3788-1722 | irene.choi@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Seoul
Branch

Andrew Tilton

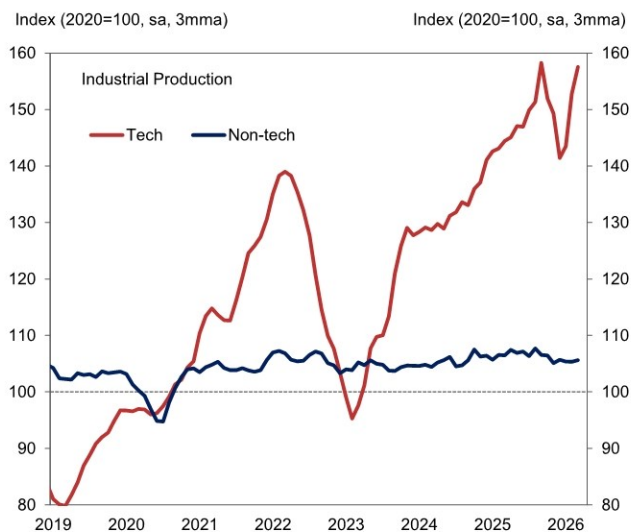
+852-2978-1802 |
andrew.tilton@gs.com
Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C.

1. We expect the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) to shift from a neutral to a more hawkish stance, reflecting strong Q1 growth and rising inflation risks from ongoing Middle East energy supply disruptions and renewed increases in metropolitan housing prices. That said, we expect any hawkish adjustment in forward guidance to remain measured, given the high uncertainty around the duration and severity of the energy shock. Policy uncertainty also remains over how the government will use sizable excess tax revenues—estimated at more than 5% of GDP—generated by major memory companies.

2. The BOK is likely to revise up its 2026 growth forecast from 1.9% toward the 2.5% consensus. Q1 GDP surprised to the upside, but the recovery remains narrow and tech-led. Tech production rose 11% qoq in Q1 (seasonally adjusted by the source, not annualized) after contracting in the prior quarter, while non-tech output was broadly flat (Exhibit 1). The split extended into April: tech exports rose 7.4% mom sa, while non-tech exports fell 4.0%. Early May export data also pointed to continued semiconductor strength and subdued non-tech exports.

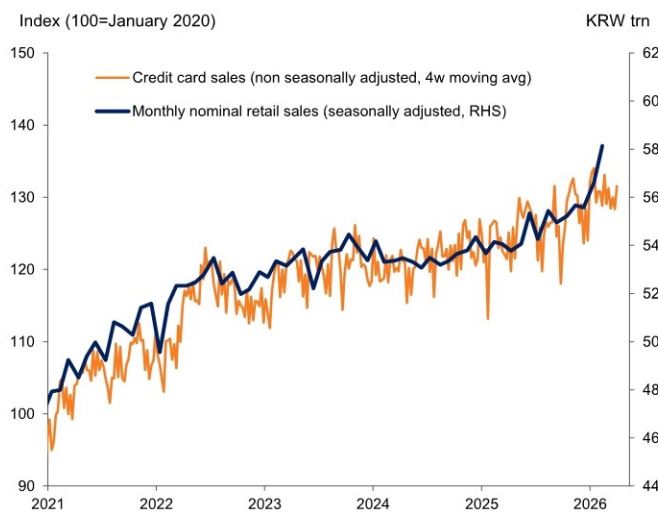
Domestic demand, by contrast, remains soft. Credit card spending pulled back in April (Exhibit 2), suggesting only limited support from this year's cash handouts. That stands in contrast to last year, when transfers coincided with a pickup in credit card expenditures. A key difference is scale: this year's program totaled KRW4.8trn (including a first round of KRW1.7trn), about one third of KRW13.2trn last year. The second round began on May 18 and runs through July 3.

Exhibit 1: Divergence between tech vs. non-tech production persists



Source: Haver Analytics

Exhibit 2: Credit card sales pulled back in April



Source: Haver Analytics

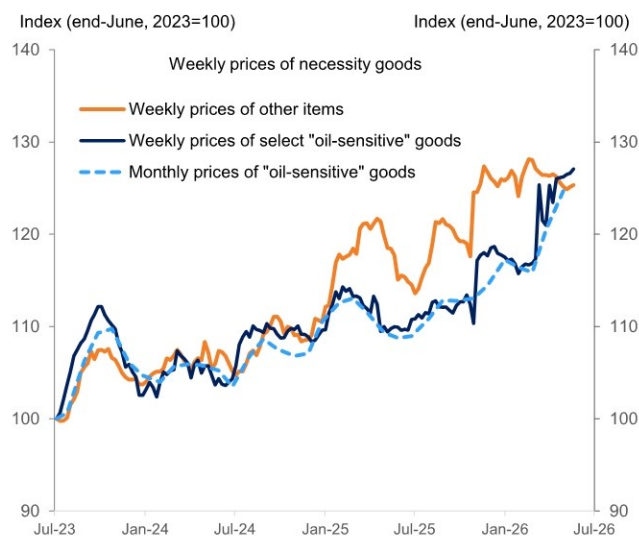
3. We expect the BOK to raise its 2026 inflation forecast from 2.3%, but only modestly. Higher energy prices are the key driver, but still-anchored inflation expectations, soft non-tech activity, and weak labor market conditions should cap the upward revision. Headline CPI rose to 2.6% yoy in April, in line with expectations, driven by oil-related goods and services.¹ High-frequency tracking points to stabilizing inflation momentum

¹ They include oil products (gasoline, diesel, cooking LPG, etc), electricity, gas and heating, delivery services, and

in May, as price gains in government-monitored “oil-sensitive” products have moderated and prices for other goods continue to fall (Exhibit 3). The BOK’s May survey also showed inflation expectations remain contained: one-year-ahead expectations fell 10bp to 2.8%, while medium-term expectations were unchanged at 2.6%.

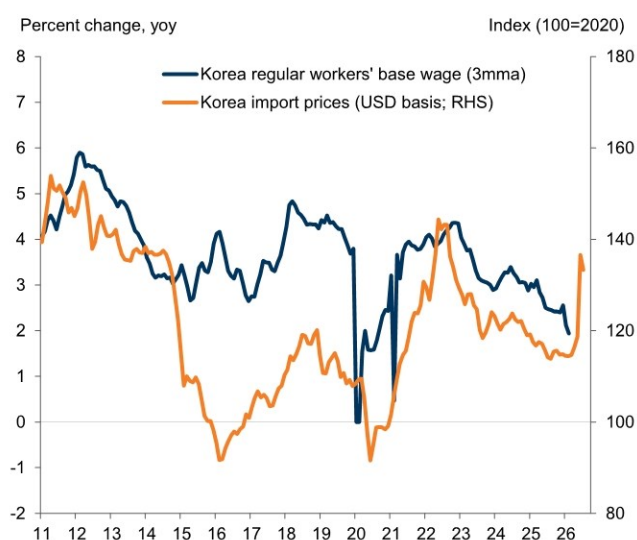
We continue to see underlying inflation as contained outside imported cost-push pressures. Base wage growth for regular workers continues to moderate in sharp contrast to the post-Covid inflation build-up in 2021–22 (Exhibit 4). We also expect limited spillovers from the AI-driven semiconductor boom to the broader labor market, given the sector’s capital-intensive nature and its share of slightly less than 1% of total employment.

Exhibit 3: High-frequency data suggest inflation moderated in May, as energy price increases slowed and other goods prices fell



Source: Korea Price Research Center, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

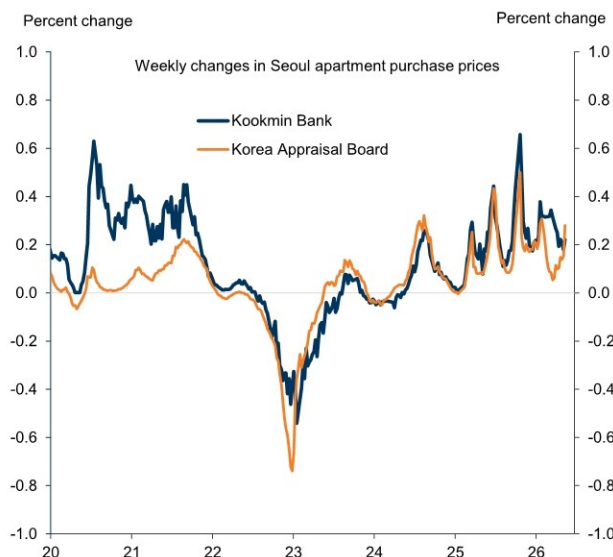
Exhibit 4: Regular workers’ wage growth continued to moderate, in contrast to the post-pandemic inflation cycle



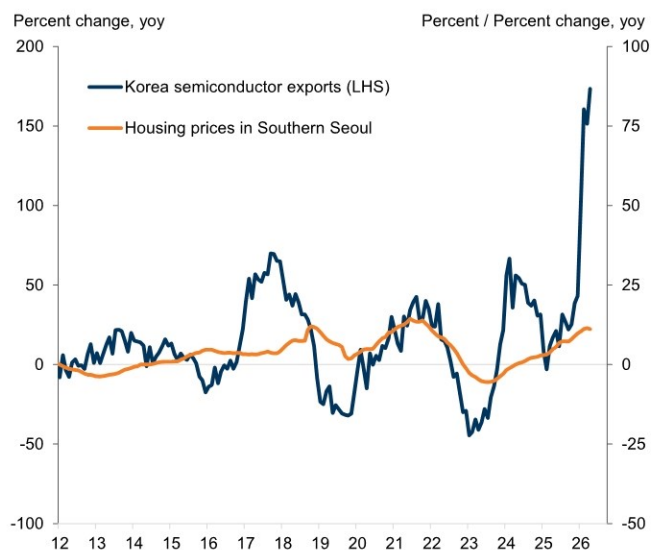
Source: Haver Analytics

Seoul housing prices have resumed rising since mid-March, with the pace of gains now the fastest since last October when the government introduced comprehensive real estate measures (Exhibit 5). The rebound has come despite the renewed government efforts to curb speculation, including stricter real estate taxes and the reinstatement of heavier capital gains taxes on multi-home owners in May. The Government has recently indicated that an upcoming tax package in July could include broader property tax increase. At the same time, capital gains from the recent outsized equity rally may be supporting housing demand in high-end metropolitan districts. Past semiconductor cycles have shown a positive correlation with Seoul housing prices, reinforcing policymakers’ concerns about renewed housing market overheating (Exhibit 6).

public transportation services.

Exhibit 5: Seoul housing prices have picked up again

Source: Haver Analytics

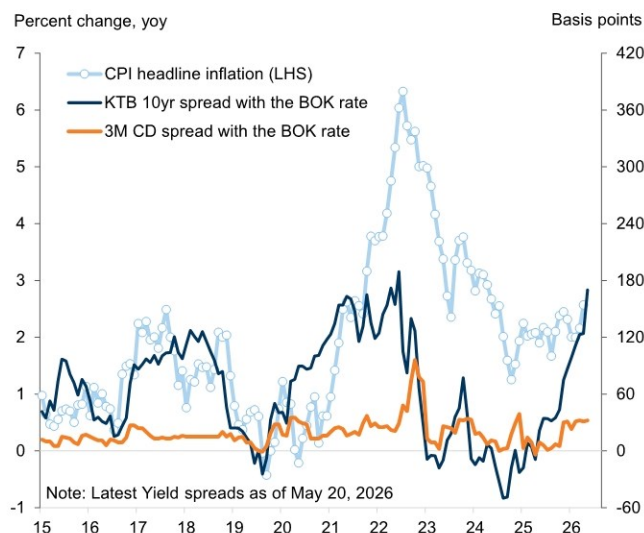
Exhibit 6: Tech cycles have tended to move along with Seoul housing prices

Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

4. The yield curve has steepened in recent weeks. The 3M CD–policy rate spread has remained broadly stable since February, supported by strong MMF inflows, likely reflecting the large and rising current account surplus ([Exhibit 8](#)). By contrast, the 10-year KTB yield rose above 4.2% in mid-May, in line with higher [global yields](#) amid ongoing Middle East disruptions and rising concerns around inflation and fiscal expansion. The 10-year spread over the policy rate has now widened to its highest level since late 2022 ([Exhibit 7](#)).

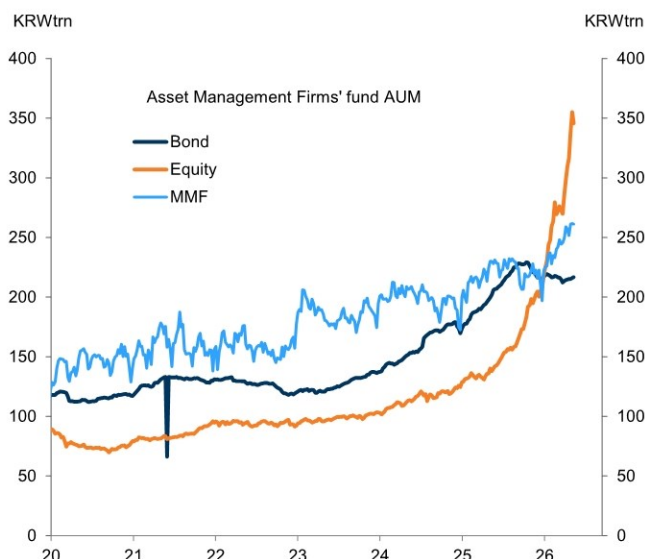
The 30-year KTB yield also rose sharply, reflecting positioning adjustments by domestic financial institutions, particularly [insurers' unwinding](#) long-duration bond forward positions totaling KRW88trn (3.3% of GDP) as of end-2025. Insurers appear to have reduced long-end exposure and duration hedges amid higher long-end volatility and [delays](#) to the implementation of K-ICS capital ratios.

Exhibit 7: KTB spreads over the policy rate have widened sharply, while 3M CD spreads have remained stable



Source: Haver Analytics

Exhibit 8: Large inflows of funds to equity and MMFs in 2026

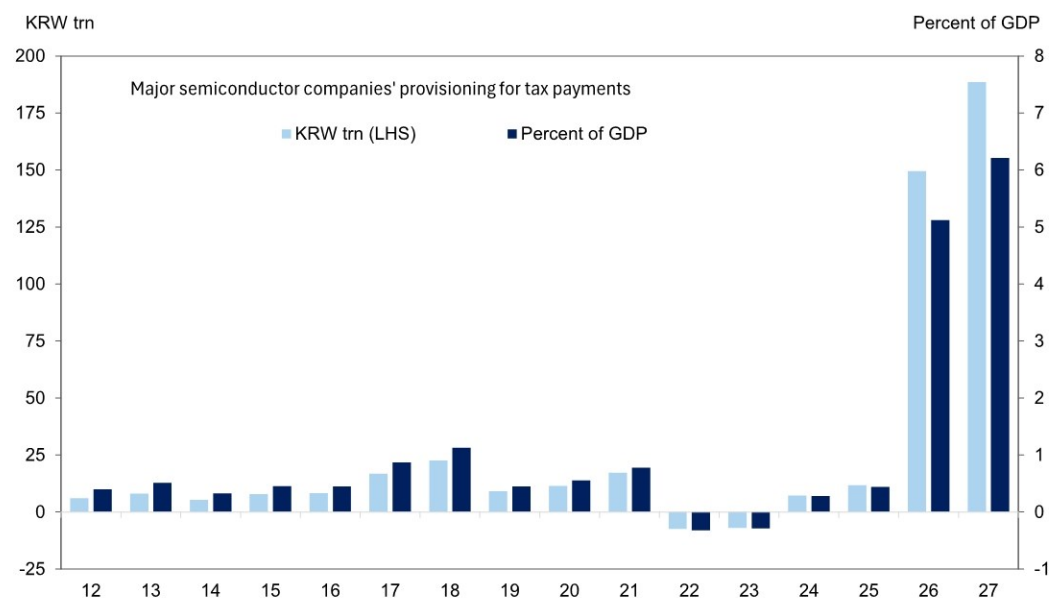


Source: Quantwise

5. While global factors are putting upward pressure on Korean yields, we think the AI-driven super surplus should provide an important offset by narrowing the fiscal deficit. Since passage of the supplementary budget, earnings forecasts for semiconductor companies have been revised up sharply. Our tech analysts estimate that 2026 tax provisioning by Korea's two largest chipmakers—most of it payable domestically—could jump to as much as KRW150trn from KRW12trn in 2025. That would materially strengthen Korea's fiscal buffer and help reduce imbalances in the FX market ([Exhibit 9](#)).²

The sharp increases in tax provisioning implies roughly KRW60trn in interim excess tax payments by end-August from major semiconductor companies, or KRW85trn including the KRW25trn already incorporated in the supplementary budget. That would be more than sufficient to cover the planned consolidated general government budget deficit of KRW52.7trn for 2026. Korea should also continue to benefit from WGBI-related flows, which we estimate could total roughly KRW55trn cumulatively this year.

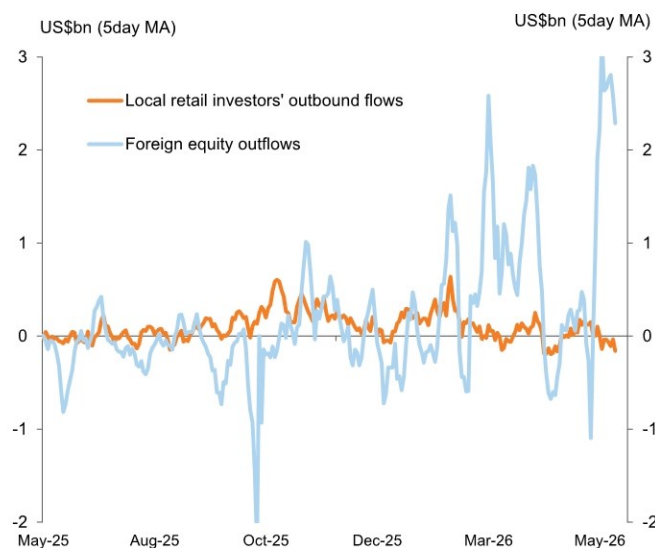
² Firms with assets exceeding KRW5trn are now required to base their August interim pre-payments on current year earnings progress rather than previous year's earnings, implying potentially significant front-loaded tax revenue gains for this year.

Exhibit 9: Large upside risks for memory companies' tax payments in 2026-27

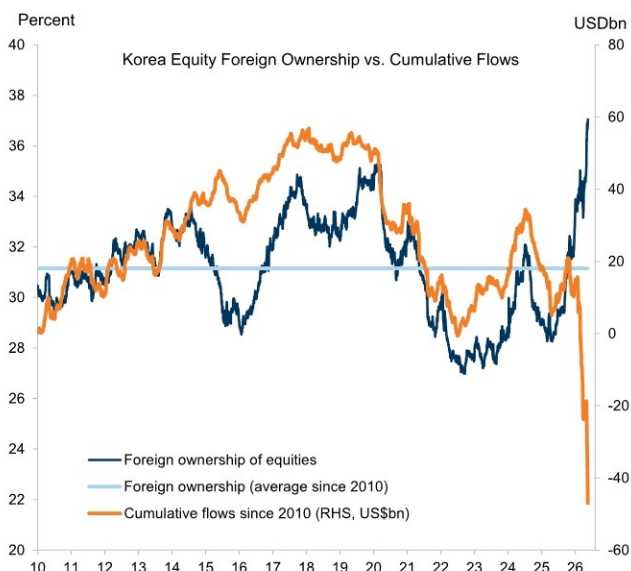
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

6. Financial flows have been a key driver of recent KRW weakness. Retail outbound flows surged in Q4, foreign equity investors' hedging demand rose in January, and foreign investors sold off Korean equities in March along with spikes in global risk aversion amid the war in the Middle East. More recently, USDKRW moved back above 1,500 together with foreign equity outflows reaching a record high of some US\$30bn in May (Exhibit 10). By contrast, local retail investment abroad slowed sharply, from outflows of US\$10bn in Q1 to marginal inflows over the last two months, likely reflecting tax incentives introduced in December 2025 and fading expectations of Fed rate cuts.

That said, we think the improving current account will become a more important driver of the KRW in coming months. Outbound flows from pension funds and retail investors should ease in 2026 on recent government measures, while KRW demand from memory companies is likely to rise sharply on local capacity expansion (US\$80bn) and interim corporate tax payments as noted above. Our strategists also argue that the recent pickup in foreign equity outflows largely reflects portfolio rebalancing and diversification rules rather than weakening corporate fundamentals (Exhibit 11). More than 90% of year-to-date foreign selling has been concentrated on the two major memory makers, and they estimate that cumulative selling tied to diversification rules has reached roughly US\$69bn since end-October. With foreign ownership in Korea's semiconductor sector now at a 10-year low despite a strong outlook for earnings, much of the foreign-driven selling may already be behind us.

Exhibit 10: Local retail investors reduced outbound flows while foreign equity investors increased outflows

Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

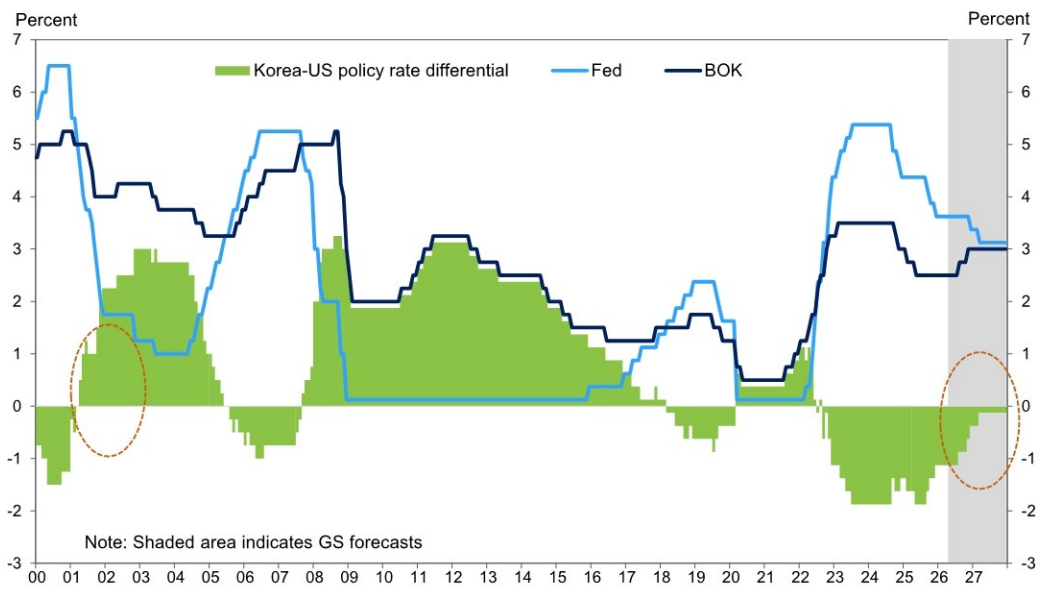
Exhibit 11: Foreign selling has accelerated due to portfolio rebalancing and diversification rules

Source: Quantiwise

7. We have recently revised our BOK policy rate forecast to two 25bp hikes in 2H, taking the policy rate to 3.00% by end-2026 ([Exhibit 12](#)). We continue to think current market pricing—roughly five hikes to 4.25% over the next 12 months—is too aggressive, given the divergence between the tech and non-tech sectors and still-muted underlying inflation pressures. Even during the post-pandemic inflation cycle, the BOK terminal rate reached only 3.5% while Korean inflation was both higher and broader-based—headline CPI peaked at 6.3% yoy in July 2022 and core inflation at 4.2% in November 2022.

We see risks to our BOK rate view as broadly balanced. If Middle East energy supply disruptions extend well beyond June, higher inflation could push the BOK to deliver more than two 25bp hikes. Likewise, monetization of AI-induced super surplus in the current account and procyclical fiscal easing—while a low-probability scenario in our view—would likely add to inflation pressures and could trigger additional tightening. On the other hand, stabilization in the Middle East and energy markets by end-June as assumed in our baseline scenario could ease inflation pressure in the second half, limiting upside risks to policy rates. Meaningful saving of excess tax revenues, and the associated reduction in the fiscal deficit, could also reduce the need for further hawkish repricing.

Exhibit 12: We expect Korea’s negative policy rate gap with the US to close in early 2027



Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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Contributing Authors: Goohoon Kwon, CFA Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Irene Choi Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C., Seoul Branch, Andrew Tilton Goldman Sachs (Asia) L.L.C..

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